

THE NEW HOLY ORDER

A new wave of reform is all set to change the religious order in a castiest Bihar with Dalits entering into priesthood

■ By Farzand Ahmed

Depending on where you stand, it could be called divine intervention, or just another social gimmick. But in a state notorious for its caste wars and violence, it has the potential to change the old religious order. The latest trend, which can bridge the gap between the upper and the lower castes, is Dalitisation. And a beginning of sorts has been made by the Bihar State Board of Religious Trusts (BSBRT), led by its administrator Acharya Kishore Kunal, who recently made a Dalit, Janardan Manjhi, the chief priest of Ram Janaki temple at Paliganj, near Patna.

According to Deputy Chief Minister Sushil Kumar Modi—who attended the *sangat-pangat* (pray together and eat together) function on the occasion of Dalits being made pujaris in Hindu temples, which have from time immemorial been the fiefdom of the Brahmins, this campaign would help bridge the caste divide and create social harmony. This wasn't the first time when a Dalit was chosen to head a prestigious temple. Manjhi is, in fact, fourth such Dalit to head a temple and his election was followed by a unique event in the state: the famous 300-year-old Khaki Baba Ram Janaki Thakurbari at Hilsa in Nalanda district came under the direct control of the Dalits with the help of BSBRT.

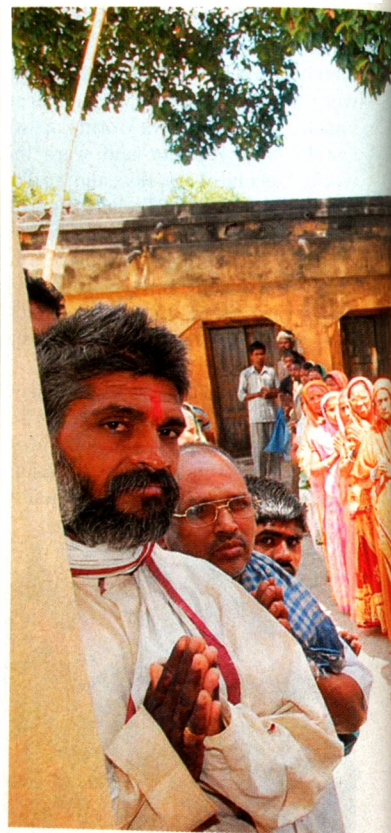
On August 10, the upper caste Hindus of the locality, with the support of Valmiki Das, a mahant, set up an all-Dalit Trust to break the Brahminical hold over society and religion. According to Kunal, a former IAS officer and a Sanskrit scholar and the chief campaigner for Dalitisation of temples in the state, a Paswan was elected as the head of the trust while its members



belonged to Ravidas, Chamar, Rajak and other Dalit sub-castes.

These instances exemplify a shift in attitude in a castiest Bihar. That such a revolutionary step will ultimately lead to a revolution, is also evident from the fact that there hasn't been any resistance from the local people, who not only enthusiastically participated in selecting and accepting Dalit priests, but also overwhelmingly attended the *sangat-pangat*, marking an end to untouchability (at least at the local level). Now every week, all sections of people assemble at temples—headed by Dalits—for common prayers and a *paath* (recitation) of Hanuman Chalisa.

There are some parallels between the Dalitisation of religious centres in Bihar and an earlier movement in the 1920s, the *Janeo Pahno Andolan* (sacred thread movement). People



belonging to lower castes weren't allowed to wear *janeo* and in a show of defiance, the Yadavs had launched this movement. They even started using 'Singh' as part of their surname in a mark of protest but this didn't last long as they faced stiff resistance from the upper castes, who feared this move would be used by the lower castes to climb the socio-economic ladder. There were clashes between the upper and the lower castes, which took a violent turn and eventually the movement was abandoned. But sociologists feel there's a greater acceptance to the present move, which marks a noticeable change in the feudal mindset. Change in the attitudes of people might just change the face of society in Bihar, they believe.

Dalitisation is also being seen as a unique way of democratising trusts and



"We don't take *purohit*'s work from a Dalit *pujari* if he is not well-versed with Sanskrit."

ACHARYA KISHORE KUNAL, ADMINISTRATOR, BSBRT